

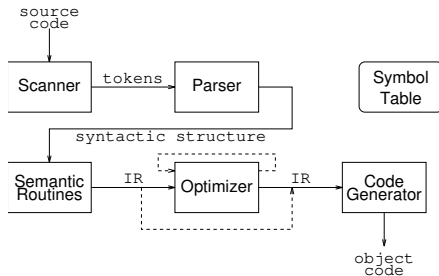
Liveness Analysis and Register Allocation

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The Compiler



Challenges in the back end

- The input to the backend: IR.
- The target program – instruction set, constraints, number of registers, etc.
- Instruction selection (undecidable): maps groups of IR instructions to one or more machine instructions. **Why not say each IR instruction maps to one more more machine level instructions?**
 - Easy, if we don't care about the efficiency.
 - Choices may be involved (add / inc); may involve understanding of the context in which the instruction appears.
- Register Allocation (NP-complete): Intermediate code has unbounded number of temporaries. Need to translate them to registers (fastest storage).
 - Finite number of registers.
 - If we cannot allocate on registers, store in the memory – will be expensive.
 - Sub problems: Register allocation, register assignment, spill location, coalescing. All NP-complete.

The Memory Hierarchy

	Access Time	Size
Registers	1 cycle	256-8000 bytes
Cache	5-10 cycles	256 KB - 40 MB
Main Memory	20-100 cycles	4 GB - 32+ GB
Disk	0.5-5M cycles	1-10 TB

Managing the Memory Hierarchy

- Most programs are written as if there are only two kinds of memory: main memory and disk.
- Programmer is responsible for moving data from disk to memory (i.e. file I/O).
- Hardware is responsible for moving data between memory and caches.
- Compiler is responsible for moving data between memory and registers.

Managing the Memory Hierarchy

- Note that there is an order of magnitude difference between register/cache access and main memory access.
- Hence, it is very important to
 - Manage caches properly.
 - Manage registers properly.
- Cache behaviour is in general unpredictable (actually undecidable).
 - Hence, as a compiler designer, managing registers properly becomes even more important!

Register allocation

Register allocation:

- have value in a register when used
- limited resources
- can affect the instruction choices
- can move loads and stores
- optimal allocation is difficult
 - ⇒ NP-complete for $k \geq 1$ registers

Basic blocks

A graph representation of intermediate code.

Each basic block is a maximal sequence of 3-address code instructions with following properties:

- The flow of control can only enter the basic block through the first instruction in the block.
- No jumps into the middle of the block.
- Control leaves the block without halting / branching (except may be the last instruction of the block).

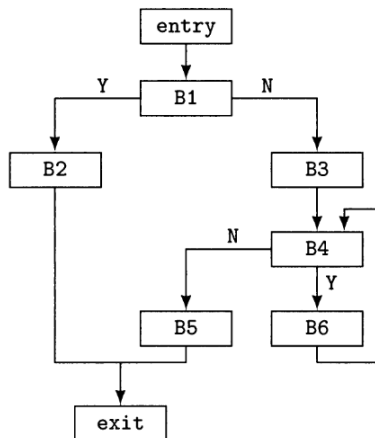
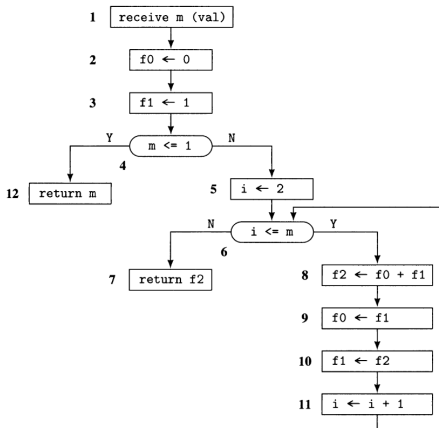
The basic blocks become the nodes of a flow graph, whose edges indicate which blocks can follow which other blocks.

Example

```
unsigned int fib(m)
{
    unsigned int m;
    { unsigned int f0 = 0, f1 = 1, f2, i;
      if (m <= 1) {
          return m;
      }
      else {
          for (i = 2; i <= m; i++) {
              f2 = f0 + f1;
              f0 = f1;
              f1 = f2;
          }
          return f2;
      }
    }
}
```

```
1      receive m (val)
2      f0 ← 0
3      f1 ← 1
4      if m <= 1 goto L3
5      i ← 2
6  L1:  if i <= m goto L2
7      return f2
8  L2:  f2 ← f0 + f1
9      f0 ← f1
10     f1 ← f2
11     i ← i + 1
12     goto L1
13  L3:  return m
```

Example - flow chart and control-flow



- The high-level abstractions might be lost in the IR.
- Control-flow analysis can expose control structures not obvious in the high level code.

Definition:

- A rooted directed graph $G = (N, E)$, where N is given by the set of basic blocks + two special BBs: `entry` and `exit`.
- And edge connects two basic blocks b_1 and b_2 if control can pass from b_1 to b_2 .
- An edge(s) from `entry` node to the initial basic block(s?)
- From each final basic blocks (with no successors) to `exit` BB.

Liveness analysis

Problem:

- IR contains an unbounded number of temporaries
- machine has bounded number of registers

Approach:

- temporaries with disjoint live ranges can map to same register
- if not enough registers then spill some temporaries (i.e., keep them in memory)

The compiler must perform liveness analysis for each temporary:

It is live if it holds a value that may be needed in future

Example

```
 $L_1 :$    $a \leftarrow 0$   
        $b \leftarrow a + 1$   
        $c \leftarrow c + b$   
       if  $c < N$  goto  $L_1$   
       return  $c$ 
```

a and b can be allocated to the same register

Example

$L_1 :$ $a \leftarrow 0$
 $b \leftarrow a + 1$
 $c \leftarrow c + b$
if $c < N$ goto L_1
return c

$L_1 :$ $r_1 \leftarrow 0$
 $r_1 \leftarrow r_1 + 1$
 $r_2 \leftarrow r_2 + r_1$
if $r_2 < N$ goto L_1
return r_2

Liveness analysis

Gathering liveness information is a form of data flow analysis operating over the CFG:

- We will treat each statement as a different basic block.
- liveness of variables “flows” through the edges of the graph
- assignments define a variable, v :
 - $def(v)$ = set of graph nodes that define v
 - $def[n]$ = set of variables defined by n where n is a BB.
- occurrences of v in expressions use it:
 - $use(v)$ = set of nodes that use v
 - $use[n]$ = set of variables used in n where n is a BB.

Definitions

- v is live on edge e if there is a directed path from e to a use of v that does not pass through any $def(v)$
- v is live-in at node n if live on any of n 's in-edges
- v is live-out at n if live on any of n 's out-edges
- $v \in use[n] \Rightarrow v$ live-in at n (recall: each statement is its own basic block).
- v live-out at $n \wedge v \notin def[n] \Rightarrow v$ live-in at n

Liveness analysis

Define:

$$\begin{aligned} in[n] &= \text{variables live-in at } n \\ out[n] &= \text{variables live-out at } n \end{aligned}$$

Then:

$$\begin{aligned} out[n] &= \bigcup_{s \in succ(n)} in[s] \\ succ[n] = \phi &\Rightarrow out[n] = \phi \end{aligned}$$

Note:

$$\begin{aligned} in[n] &\supseteq use[n] \\ in[n] &\supseteq out[n] - def[n] \end{aligned}$$

$use[n]$ and $def[n]$ are constant (independent of control flow)

Now, $v \in in[n]$ iff. $v \in use[n]$ or $v \in out[n] - def[n]$

Thus, $in[n] = use[n] \cup (out[n] - def[n])$

Iterative solution for liveness

N : Set of nodes of CFG;

foreach $\underline{n \in N}$ **do**

$in[n] \leftarrow \phi$;
 $out[n] \leftarrow \phi$;

end

repeat

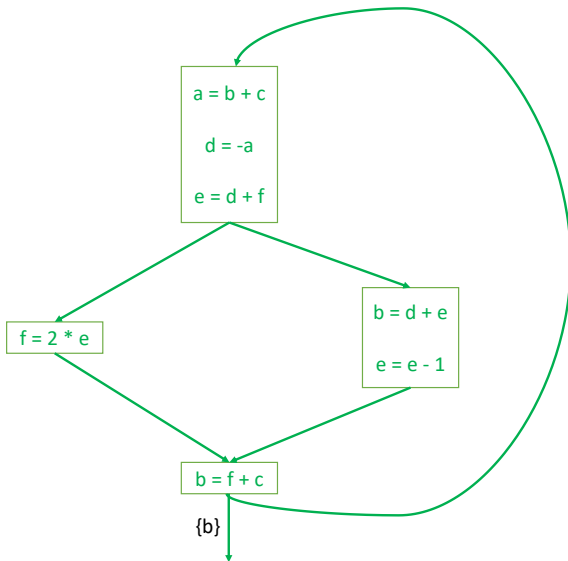
foreach $\underline{n \in \text{Nodes}}$ **do**

$in'[n] \leftarrow in[n]$;
 $out'[n] \leftarrow out[n]$;
 $in[n] \leftarrow use[n] \cup (out[n] - def[n])$;
 $out[n] \leftarrow \bigcup_{s \in succ[n]} in[s]$;

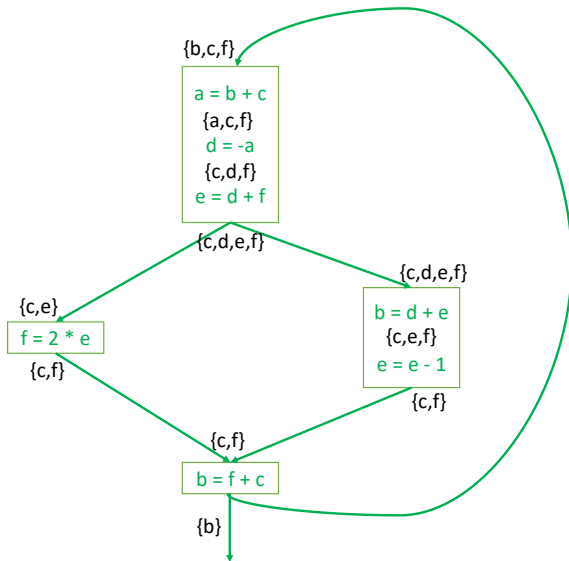
end

until $\underline{\forall n, in'[n] = in[n] \wedge out'[n] = out[n]}$;

Example



Example



- should order computation of inner loop of the data-flow analysis algorithm to follow the “flow”
- liveness flows backward along control-flow arcs, from out to in
- nodes can just as easily be basic blocks to reduce CFG size
- could do one variable at a time, from uses back to defs, noting liveness along the way

Iterative solution for liveness

Complexity: for input program of size N

- $\leq N$ nodes in CFG
 - $\Rightarrow \leq N$ variables
 - $\Rightarrow N$ elements per *in/out*
 - $\Rightarrow O(N)$ time per set-union
 - **for** loop performs constant number of set operations per node
 - $\Rightarrow O(N^2)$ time for **for** loop
 - each iteration of **repeat** loop can only add to each set
 - sets can contain at most every variable
 - $\Rightarrow$ sizes of all in and out sets sum to $2N^2$,
 - bounding the number of iterations of the **repeat** loop
- $\Rightarrow$ worst-case complexity of $O(N^4)$
- ordering can cut **repeat** loop down to 2-3 iterations
 - $\Rightarrow O(N)$ or $O(N^2)$ in practice

Least fixed points

There is often more than one solution for a given dataflow problem.

- For example, if a variable x is never used or defined, then adding x to the *in* and *out* sets of every basic block is also a valid solution.

Many possible solutions but we want the “smallest”: the least fixpoint. The iterative algorithm computes this least fixpoint.

Any solution to dataflow equations is a conservative approximation:

- v has some later use downstream from n
 $\Rightarrow v \in out(n)$
- but not the converse

Conservatively assuming a variable is live does not break the program; just means more registers may be needed.

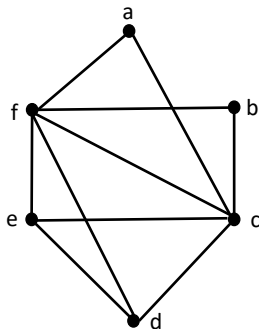
Assuming a variable is dead when really live will break things.

Register Interference Graph

- An undirected graph
 - A node for each temporary/variable.
 - An edge between t_1 and t_2 if they are live simultaneously at some point in the program.
- Two temporaries can be allocated to the same register if there is no edge connecting them.
- The register interference graph extracts exactly the information needed to perform legal register assignments.
- Also gives a global picture (i.e. over the entire flow graph) of the register requirements.

Example: Register Interference Graph

The Register Interference Graph for our example program:

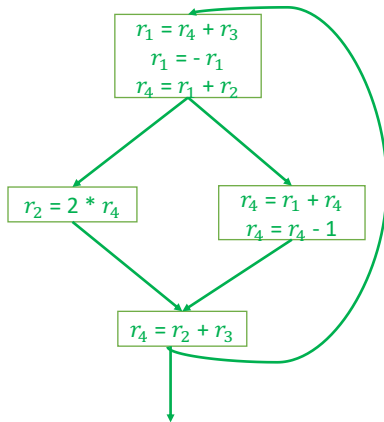
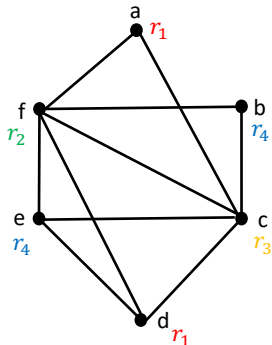


- b and c cannot be assigned the same register.
- b and d can be assigned the same register.
- How many registers? Same as the number of colors required for coloring the graph.

Register allocation - by Graph coloring

- Step 1:
 - Select target machine instructions assuming infinite registers (temps).
 - If a instruction requires a special register – replace that temp with that register.
- Step 2:
 - Construct the interference graph.
 - Solve the register allocation problem by coloring the graph.
 - A graph is said to be colored if each pair of neighboring nodes have different colors.

Example: Colored RIG



Computing Graph Colorings

- How do we compute graph colorings?
- The problem is NP-Hard. No efficient algorithms are known.
 - Solution: We will use heuristics.
- A coloring may not exist for a given number of registers/colors.
 - Solution: We will use systematic spilling.

Graph Coloring Heuristic

- Observation:
 - Pick a node t with fewer than k neighbours in RIG.
 - Eliminate t and its edges from RIG.
 - If the resulting graph is k -colorable, then so is the original graph.
- Why?
 - Let $c_1, c_2, \dots, c_n$ be the colors assigned to neighbours of t in the reduced graph.
 - Since $n < k$, we can pick a color for t among k colors that is different from those of its neighbours.

Graph coloring - a simplistic approach

Input: G - the interference graph, k - number of colors

repeat

repeat

 Remove a node n and all its edges from G , such that degree of n is less than K ;

 Push n onto a stack;

until G has no node with degree less than k ;

 // G is either empty or all of its nodes have degree $\geq k$

if G is not empty **then**

 Take one node m out of G , and mark it for spilling;

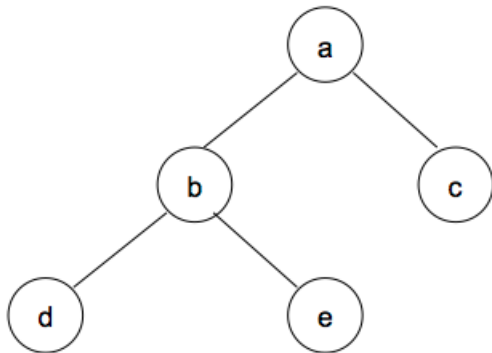
 Remove all the edges of m from G ;

end

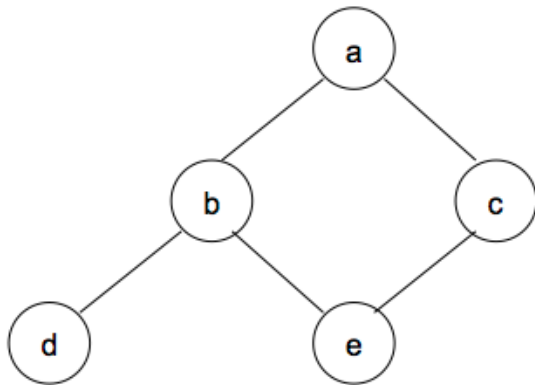
until G is empty;

Take one node at a time from the stack and assign a non conflicting color.

Example 1, available colors = 2



Example 2



We have to spill.

Graph coloring - Kempe's heuristic

- Algorithm dating back to 1879.
- Also called 'optimistic coloring'.

Input: G - the interference graph, K - number of colors

repeat

repeat

 Remove a node n and all its edges from G , such that degree of n is less than K ;

 Push n onto a stack;

until G has no node with degree less than K ;

 // G is either empty or all of its nodes have degree $\geq K$

if G is not empty **then**

 Take one node m out of G .;

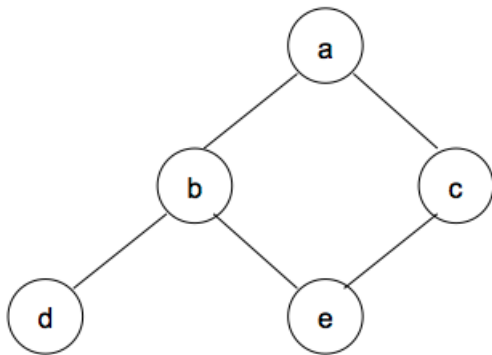
 push m onto the stack;

end

until G is empty;

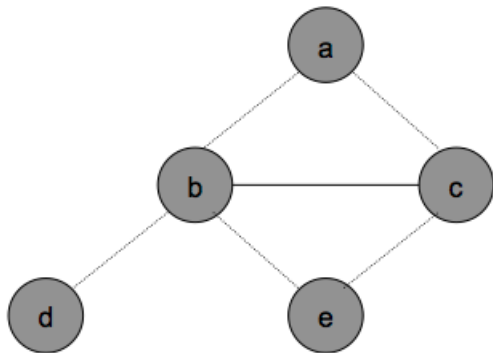
Take one node at a time from the stack and assign a non conflicting color (if possible, else spill).

Example 2 (revisited)



We don't have to spill.

Example 3

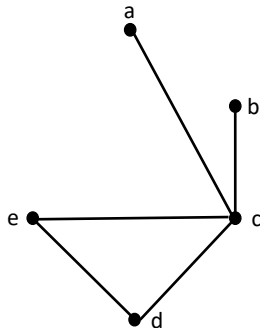
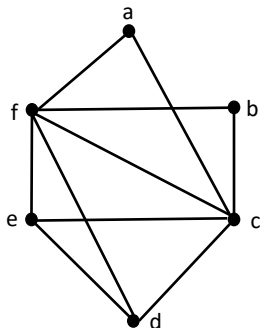


Don't have a choice. Have to spill.

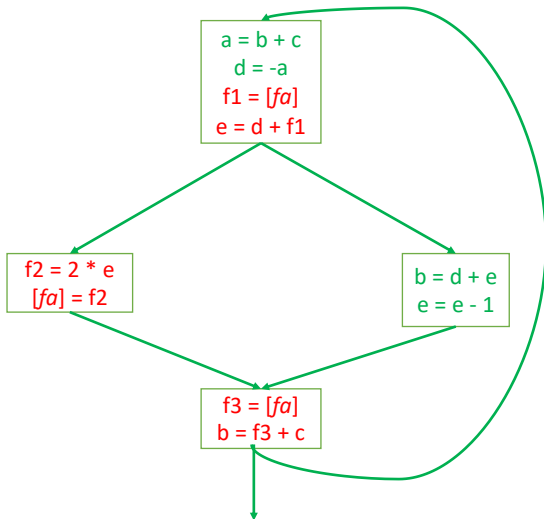
- We need to generate extra instructions to load variables from the stack and store them back.
- The load and store may require registers again:
 - Naive approach: Keep a separate register (wasteful).
 - Rewrite the code - by introducing a temporary; rerun the liveness + register-allocation
(Note: the new temp has much smaller live range).

Example: Spilling

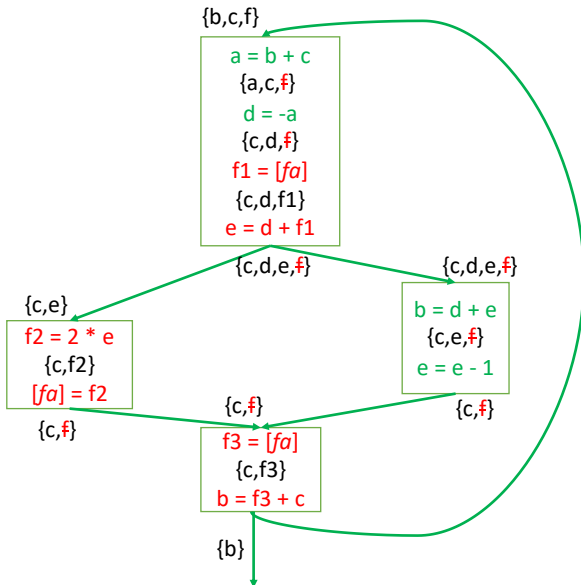
Going back to our running example, suppose we only have 3 registers, and decide to spill f .



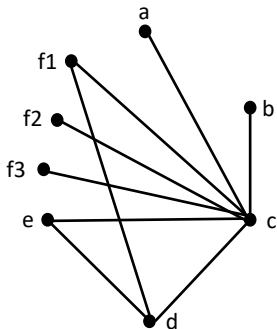
Example: Rewrite for spilled variable



Example: Recomputing Liveness after rewrite



Example: RIG after rewrite



Homework: Find a register allocation using 3 registers, and rewrite the program using the allocated registers.

Criteria for spilling

During register allocation, we identify that one of the live ranges from a given set has to be spilled. What should be the criteria?

- Random
- One with maximum degree
- One that has the longest life
- One with the shortest life (take advantage of the cache)
- One with least cost
 - Cost = Dynamic (load + store cost)
 - How to handle loops, conditionals?
 - Cost of load and store
 - More details in the book, Chapter 8, Section 8.8.2

Register allocation - Linear scan

Register allocation is **expensive**.

- Many algorithms use heuristics for graph coloring.
- Allocation may take time quadratic in the number of live intervals.

Not suitable

- Online compilers – need to generate code quickly. e.g. JIT compilers.
- Sacrifice efficient register allocation for compilation speed.

Linear scan register allocation - Massimiliano Poletto and Vivek Sarkar, ACM TOPLAS 1999

Self-study: Section 4 of the above paper.

Linear Scan algorithm

LINEARSCANREGISTERALLOCATION

active $\leftarrow \{\}$

foreach live interval *i*, in order of increasing start point

 EXPIREOLDINTERVALS(*i*)

if length(*active*) = *R* **then**

 SPILLATINTERVAL(*i*)

else

register[*i*] $\leftarrow$ a register removed from pool of free registers

 add *i* to *active*, sorted by increasing end point

EXPIREOLDINTERVALS(*i*)

foreach interval *j* in *active*, in order of increasing end point

if *endpoint*[*j*] $\geq$ *startpoint*[*i*] **then**

return

 remove *j* from *active*

 add *register*[*j*] to pool of free registers

SPILLATINTERVAL(*i*)

spill $\leftarrow$ last interval in *active*

if *endpoint*[*spill*] > *endpoint*[*i*] **then**

register[*i*] $\leftarrow$ *register*[*spill*]

location[*spill*] $\leftarrow$ new stack location

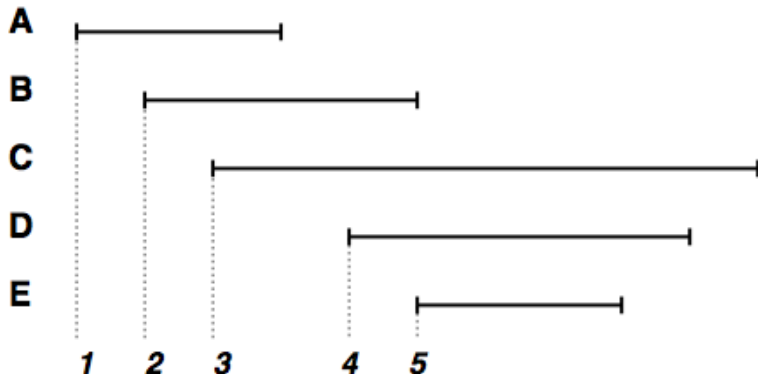
 remove *spill* from *active*

 add *i* to *active*, sorted by increasing end point

else

location[*i*] $\leftarrow$ new stack location

Example



- Say, available registers = 2

Linear Scan algorithm - analysis

- Each live range gets either a register or a spill location.
- Note: The number of overlapping intervals changes only at the start and end points of an interval.
- Live intervals are stored in a list that is sorted in order of increasing start point.
- The active list is kept sorted in order of increasing end point. Adv: need to scan only those intervals (+1 at most) that have to be removed.
- Complexity: $O(V)$ – if number of registers is assumed to be a constant. Else? $O(V \times \log R)$
- Many more details can be found in the paper.
 - Study section 4 of the paper (Poletto et al. ACM TOPLAS 1999).